

tune to a particular frequency and listen to the signals coming from the GPS satellites. The number of satellites transmitting signals to the receiver determines the accuracy of the reading.

However, GPS receivers do not have the ability to relay this information. This is where the need for a wireless network arises, which could be terrestrial networks such as GSM, CDMA, CDPD, VHF, etc. It could also be a non-terrestrial network such as a satellite network, which is capable of transmitting data from the object to the asset manager's control room.

Next, the 'short messages' provided by the GSM network can be used to relay the data from the m-Trak device to the asset manager's office/control room. The GSM modem periodically receives these messages in near real-time. The GSM modem then transmits these to the m-Trak software, which processes them and plots them on a visual map.

The m-Trak device provides support for off-line storage of location data in the device as well. This is useful when the asset is in a remote area where the terrestrial network coverage is absent. So, there will be a brief period when the asset manager would not be able to track the asset in real-time. In such a scenario, in order to prevent loss of tracking data, the software allows for storage of location data locally in the device. Once the asset comes back into a coverage area, the stored data is transmitted back to the control room. The asset manager would now be able to view the path taken by the asset in the off-coverage area.

### Customers Galore!

Asset tracking can be cost-effective for the following customers:

- Industries where a production assembly line depends on raw materials arriving 'just in time'
- Hazardous chemicals and gas manufacturers who require safe transportation of their goods
- Companies manufacturing high value goods that require safety against pilferage
- Transporters of frozen/perishable goods
- Courier and express cargo companies who require tracking of consignments
- Taxi operators, who require optimal usage of their fleet by despatching the nearest cab to a customer point
- Public transportation systems that require tracking of buses to provide real-time updates on arrival and departure to passengers
- Companies that require a billing of mileage
- Police force for patrolling, etc.

Currently, MobiApps' list of clients includes the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMT), Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC), Safexpress,

Dell, Ford Motor Company, General Motors Corporation, Hyundai Motor India Limited, Praxair Inc., Transport Corporation of India, Ltd. (TCIL), Life Fitness, Mercury and Wipro, amongst others.

To understand what customers think, we spoke to Ankit Kumar, manager, Network HICON, Safexpress Pvt Ltd, a bangalore based provider of a range of logistics and supply chain solutions including door-to-door distribution, single source invoicing, reverse logistics, packaging solutions, etc. Their network comprises over 513 locations of more than 2,400 vehicles, operating over 750 routes, 365 days a year. MobiApps is providing fleet management solution to track and manage their logistics operations.

"We have about 3,000 vehicles in all on our fleet, for which we have started planning implementation of the tracking system. We started using the m-Trak system about eight months ago



and have been very satisfied. We have noticed a huge difference in the stoppages, time taken, departures, etc. and are quite satisfied with the system," says Kumar.

### Looking Forward

After a tie-up with the Tata Group MobiApps is very bullish about its future. "There is a large customer base that we are yet to tap into," says Amitabh Satyam, Country Head, MobiApps. Like any other Indian IT-services provider, MobiApps too to expand its business beyond India shores. Southeast Asia and the Middle-East are the areas of focus for this logistics application provider.

But is the Indian market ready for a high-tech tool such as m-Trak? MobiApps says that it has a survey to back-up its claims about the large customer base. However, convincing the smaller transporters about the long-term benefits that can be derived from using the software is not going to be easy. And considering that the Indian transport sector is largely unorganised and survives on very small margins, only time will tell whether MobiApps, with its fancy logistical tool, will be able to crack the market. ■

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